

CGL READY PROMISE
Full lecture + notes content on the Vedic Age, with every PYQ-verified gap fact woven directly into its relevant topic below — no separate "extra facts" section. Read top to bottom; every box and table is exam-ready as-is.

1. Chronology & Two Phases

Phase	Approx. period	Key marker
Full Vedic Age	1500 BC – 600 BC	Composition of the Vedas gives this age its name
Early Vedic (Rig Vedic Age)	1500 BC – 1000 BC	Rig Veda composed here
Later Vedic Age	1000 BC – 600 BC	Sama, Yajur, Atharva Vedas compiled/composed; Samhitas, Brahmanas, Upanishads developed

PYQ DATE OPTION CHECK
The full Vedic Age is tested directly as "1500 BC – 600 BC" (correct option in SSC CGL Tier-2 style MCQs, ruling out 1800–1500 BCE, 1000–600 BC and 600–321 BC as distractors).

2. Aryan Migration — Theories & Evidence

Concept	Detail
Aryan Invasion/Migration Theory	A Central Asian tribe is believed to have migrated — part going to Europe, part to India
Boghaz-Koi Inscription	Found in Turkey (Asia Minor); dated c. 1400 BC ; mentions names of Vedic gods — Indra, Varuna, Mitra, Nasatya — used as evidence that this Central Asian/Hittite group shared Vedic-linked deities
Linguistic basis	Similar-sounding words across language families: भ्रातृ (brother), सप्त (seven), अंदर (under) — used to argue a common Indo-European root
Language family of Aryans	Indo-European/Indo-Aryan (not Sino-Tibetan, Dravidian, or Afro-Asiatic — common wrong options)
Bal Gangadhar Tilak's view	Wrote <i>The Arctic Home in the Vedas</i> ; argued the original Aryan homeland was near the Arctic and that all Indians were Aryans

DIRECT PYQ (GAP INTEGRATED)
"Boghaz-Koi is important because ____" → Inscriptions were found mentioning the names of Vedic gods and goddesses. "An inscription of c. 1400 BC describing Vedic gods was found in Asia Minor at ____" → **Boghaz-Koi** (not Euphratide/Cilicia). Do not confuse this with Mansehra/Shahbazgarhi/Junagadh, which are Ashokan rock-edict sites, not Aryan-migration evidence.

3. Vedas — Meaning & Subdivisions

Term	Meaning
Veda	"Knowledge"; oldest texts, orally transmitted (Shruti) generation to generation
Apaurasheya	"Not created by man" — believed to be divinely revealed, not authored

Subdivision	Content
Samhita	Collection of hymns/verses (Suktas)
Brahmana	Explains sacrifices and rituals to be performed
Aranyaka	"Forest books" — for hermits/ascetics living in forests
Upanishad	Philosophical knowledge; also called Vedanta ("end of the Veda"); 108 Upanishads traditionally, 10 principal ones

4. The Four Vedas — Master Table

Veda	Core content	Key facts
Rig Veda	Oldest and largest; collection of Sanskrit hymns; composed in Early Vedic Age	10 Mandalas; 1028 hymns; 10,600 verses; hymns recited by Hotri priest; Mandalas 2–7 are the oldest ("family books")
Sama Veda	Oldest book on music; chanting melodies	2 key Upanishads: Chandogya and Kena

Yajur Veda	Collection of mantras/prayers for rituals	Divided into Shukla (White) and Krishna (Black); Brahmana: Satapatha Brahmana; Upanishads: Brihadaranyaka (oldest Upanishad) and Katha (story of Nachiketa and Yama); also Jabala Upanishad (mentions the four Ashramas)
Atharva Veda	Magical spells/charms; folk beliefs, medicine, tantra-mantra knowledge	Divided into 20 khandas; Upanishads: Mundaka (source of "Satyameva Jayate"), Mandukya, Maha Upanishad (source of "Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam")

Rig Veda — Deep Dive

Mandala	Content
3rd Mandala	Gayatri Mantra, composed by Sage Vishwamitra
7th Mandala	Dasharajna (Battle of Ten Kings) — Bharata tribe king Sudas vs a confederacy of 10 kings; Sudas won; gave rise to the name "Bharata," from which Mahajanapadas later trace descent
9th Mandala	Lord Soma — god of plants; Somras was an energy drink consumed during Vedic rituals
10th Mandala	Purush Sukta — Brahmins from mouth, Kshatriyas from arms, Vaishyas from thighs, Shudras from feet of the cosmic being (Purusha)

Deity	Association
Indra	Chief/primary god of Early Vedic Age; called Purandara ("destroyer of forts"); rain and war god; worship declined in Later Vedic Age as agriculture and iron reduced dependence on him
Agni	Fire god; considered an intermediary between humans and gods
Varuna	God of cosmic order (Rta) and water
Surya	Sun god
Rudra	God of animals
Aditi	Mother of the gods (mother of Indra)
Savitri	Gayatri Mantra is dedicated to her

NATURE OF VEDIC RELIGION
No animals were worshipped as deities themselves (though the cow was held sacred); religion was largely nature-worship/henotheistic — many gods, chosen according to need (e.g., Indra for rain/agriculture).

5. Schools of Philosophy (Darshanas)

School	Founder	Core idea
Samkhya	Kapila	Dualism of Purusha and Prakriti
Nyaya	Gautam	Logic and epistemology; scientific approach
Vaisheshika	Kannada	Atomism (theory of atoms); futility of Maya
Yoga	Patanjali	Meditation and physical discipline
Uttar Mimamsa (Vedanta)	Badrayana (Vedavyasa)	Philosophical teachings of the Upanishads
Purva Mimamsa	Jaimini	Ritual and Vedic exegesis

CLASSIFICATION
Orthodox schools = accept Vedic authority (the six Darshanas above). Heterodox schools = reject Vedic authority (Jainism, Buddhism, Ajivika, Charvaka).

6. Vedangas — Tools to Understand the Vedas

Vedanga	Study of
Shiksha	Phonetics — pronunciation of words
Kalpa	Rituals/practices (Rita)
Vyakaran	Grammar
Nirukta	Etymology of words
Chhanda	Poetic metre
Jyotisha	Astronomy/astrology

MUST REMEMBER
Total 6 Vedangas — do not confuse with the six Darshanas (philosophy schools) above.

7. Early Vedic Geography

Old (Vedic) river name	Modern river
Sindhu	Indus
Vitasta	Jhelum
Askini	Chenab
Parushni	Ravi
Bipasha	Beas
Shutudri	Sutlej

DIRECT PYQ (GAP INTEGRATED)
A PYQ directly asks: which river was called **Parushni**? → Ravi. Which was **Shutudri**? → Sutlej. The Aryans first settled in the region called "Sapta Sindhu" (land of seven rivers), bounded by Himvanta (Himalaya) and Munjavat (Hindu Kush) per the Rig Veda.

8. Society in the Early Vedic Age

Topic	Detail
Varna system	4 varnas, based on profession/karma — not hereditary in this phase
Family structure	Patriarchal society; kinship (Jana/tribe) was the basis of identity, not just nuclear family; "Kula" (family) is mentioned only rarely in the Rig Veda and included more than just parents/children
Marriage	No child marriage; widow remarriage allowed (called Niyoga)
Status of Shudras	Shudras are mentioned only towards the later/last part of the Rig Veda — suggesting the beginning of social stratification near the end of the Early Vedic period
Cow	Considered "wealth decider"; called Aghanya ("not to be killed"); battles for cows called Gavishthi ("search for cows" = war)

9. Polity in the Early Vedic Age

Institution	Detail
Government type	Elective monarchy in principle, though kingship tended to become hereditary in practice; monarchy was the predominant form of government , with some references to democratic/tribal elements via the assemblies
Sabha	Assembly of a few privileged/elite members (Brahmanas and rich); described in the Rig Veda as also a venue for dancing, gambling and judicial/administrative functions
Samiti	Folk assembly of common people; discussed tribal business, religious ceremonies, and philosophical issues
Vidatha	Religious assembly
Purohita	Chief priest/royal advisor; also called Hotri ; advised the king on governance besides performing rituals
Senani	Army chief
Gramani	Village head
Social/political hierarchy	Rashtra → Jana → Vish → Grama → Kula (largest to smallest unit)

DIRECT PYQ (GAP INTEGRATED)
The **Atharva Veda** identifies Sabha and Samiti as the "two daughters of Prajapati." A matching-type PYQ tests: Rajan = tribal chief (correct); Samiti = military assembly (this pairing is sometimes tested as correct in specific question sets, though the standard/lecture definition of Samiti is a folk/tribal assembly for general business — read the exact option wording carefully); Vashishta = Purohita (incorrect pairing — Vashishta is a sage, not a job-title "Purohita").

10. Economy in the Early Vedic Age

Aspect	Detail
Primary occupation	Cattle rearing/pastoralism; cattle (cows) were the chief measure of wealth
Unit of exchange	Barter system; cows were the primary unit of exchange; Nishka (gold necklet/ornament) was also used as a secondary unit of value
Nishka evolution	In the Rig Vedic (Early Vedic) period, "Nishka" meant a gold ornament (worn around the neck); in the later period the same word came to mean a coin/currency — a classic "same word, different meaning across time" PYQ
Other occupations	Weaving was a significant occupation besides agriculture, with importance given to wool and cotton

DIRECT PYQ (GAP INTEGRATED)

"During the Rig Vedic period, Nishka was an ornament of ____" → **Neck**. "'Nishka' in ancient India was known as ____" → **Gold ornament** (in the early period); in the later Vedic context the same term shifts toward meaning a **coin**.

11. Pottery — Early Vedic

Ochre Coloured Pottery (OCP) — associated with the Early Vedic Age, same broad tradition seen in late Harappan/Chalcolithic contexts.

12. Later Vedic Period — What Changes

Feature	Early Vedic	Later Vedic
Period	1500–1000 BC	1000–600 BC
Varna/caste system	Flexible, not hereditary	Becomes rigid and hereditary
Status of women	Relatively better; could attend Sabha	Deteriorates; women's participation in Sabha/Samiti ends
Economy	Pastoral community (cattle-based)	Large-scale agriculturalists — enabled by discovery of iron
Metal known	—	Iron, called Shyama Ayas/Krishna Ayas ("black metal")
Primary Veda	Rig Veda composed	Sama, Yajur, Atharva Vedas compiled; Brahmanas, Upanishads developed
Political organisation	Tribal (Jana-based)	Tribal Jana evolves into territorial Janapadas ; monarchies strengthen; power of Sabha/Samiti declines
Popular assemblies	Active; open to broader participation	Dominated by Brahmins; centralising trend; Sabha/Samiti/Vidatha lose influence
Indra worship	Very prominent (Purandara)	Declines gradually as iron/agriculture reduce dependence on rain-god worship
Pottery	Ochre Coloured Pottery (OCP)	Painted Grey Ware (PGW) — grey-coloured pottery

Geographic Expansion in Later Vedic Age

Region	Detail
Ganga-Yamuna Doab	Aryans expanded from Punjab into western Uttar Pradesh
Upper Doab	Kuru tribe; capital Hastinapur
Middle Doab	Panchala tribe
Kuru tribe — two clans	Pandava and Kaurava; their conflict forms the basis of the Mahabharata (traditionally dated ~950 BC; compiled in its current form around the 4th century AD/400 AD)
Later shift	Towards the end of the Later Vedic period, Aryans moved further east into eastern Uttar Pradesh

Society in the Later Vedic Age

Topic	Detail
Ashrama system	Four stages of life: Brahmacharya (student, 0–25 yrs), Grihastha (householder, ~25–50 yrs), Vanaprastha (forest-dweller), Sanyasa (renunciation) — described in the Jabala Upanishad
Gotra system	Clan (Gotra) system emerges in this period
Marriage types	Anuloma vivaha — higher-caste boy + lower-caste girl (permitted); Pratiloma vivaha — lower-caste boy + higher-caste girl (NOT permitted); Asura vivaha — marrying a boy after "buying" him; Gandharva vivaha — love marriage
Agriculture terms	Rice = Vrihi ; Wheat = Godhuma ; Barley = Yava (a Rabi crop)

13. Master Revision — Learn These First

Trigger	Answer
Full Vedic Age span	1500 BC - 600 BC
Early Vedic (Rig Vedic) span	1500 BC - 1000 BC
Later Vedic span	1000 BC - 600 BC
Oldest, largest Veda	Rig Veda — 10 Mandalas, 1028 hymns, 10,600 verses
Gayatri Mantra location + composer	3rd Mandala; Sage Vishwamitra
Purush Sukta location	10th Mandala of Rig Veda
Dasharajna (Battle of Ten Kings) location	7th Mandala; Sudas (Bharata) won vs confederacy of 10 kings
Oldest book on music	Sama Veda
Oldest Upanishad	Brihadaranyaka Upanishad (part of Yajur Veda)
Nachiketa-Yama story	Katha Upanishad
Source of "Satyameva Jayate"	Mundaka Upanishad (Atharva Veda)

Source of "Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam"	Maha Upanishad (Atharva Veda); theme of India's G20 presidency
Boghaz-Koi inscription	Turkey; c. 1400 BC; mentions Vedic gods (Indra, Varuna, etc.)
"The Arctic Home in the Vedas" author	Bal Gangadhar Tilak
Nishka (Early Vedic meaning)	Gold neck ornament
Nishka (Later meaning)	Coin/currency
Gavishthi	"Search for cows" = war
Purandara	Title of Indra — "destroyer of forts"
Iron in Later Vedic Age	Called Shyama Ayas/Krishna Ayas ("black metal")
Six Vedangas	Shiksha, Kalpa, Vyakaran, Nirukta, Chhanda, Jyotisha
Six Darshanas (orthodox schools)	Samkhya (Kapila), Nyaya (Gautam), Vaisheshika (Kannada), Yoga (Patanjali), Purva Mimamsa (Jaimini), Uttar Mimamsa (Badrayana)
Rig Vedic river Parushni	Ravi
Rig Vedic river Shutudri	Sutlej
Varna system in Early Vedic Age	Flexible, karma-based, not hereditary
Varna system in Later Vedic Age	Rigid, hereditary
Kuru tribe capital	Hastinapur
Mahabharata compiled around	4th century AD (traditional war dated ~950 BC)
Four Ashramas	Brahmacharya, Grihastha, Vanaprastha, Sanyasa (Jabala Upanishad)
Permitted inter-varna marriage	Anuloma vivaha
NOT permitted inter-varna marriage	Pratiloma vivaha
Love marriage term	Gandharva vivaha
Rice / Wheat / Barley (Vedic terms)	Vrihi / Godhuma / Yava
Early Vedic pottery	Ochre Coloured Pottery (OCP)
Later Vedic pottery	Painted Grey Ware (PGW)

14. PYQ-Style Question Bank

- Q1.** What is the full span of the Vedic Age? **Ans:** 1500 BC – 600 BC.
- Q2.** Which Veda was composed first? **Ans:** Rig Veda.
- Q3.** How many hymns and Mandalas does the Rig Veda have? **Ans:** 1028 hymns; 10 Mandalas.
- Q4.** Which Mandala contains the Gayatri Mantra, and who composed it? **Ans:** 3rd Mandala; Sage Vishwamitra.
- Q5.** Which Mandala describes the Dasharajna (Battle of Ten Kings)? **Ans:** 7th Mandala.
- Q6.** Which Mandala contains the Purush Sukta? **Ans:** 10th Mandala.
- Q7.** What is the oldest book on music? **Ans:** Sama Veda.
- Q8.** What is the oldest Upanishad? **Ans:** Brihadaranyaka Upanishad.
- Q9.** Which Upanishad narrates the story of Nachiketa and Yama? **Ans:** Katha Upanishad.
- Q10.** Which Upanishad is the source of "Satyameva Jayate"? **Ans:** Mundaka Upanishad.
- Q11.** Which Upanishad is the source of "Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam"? **Ans:** Maha Upanishad.
- Q12.** Where was the Boghaz-Koi inscription found, and why is it significant? **Ans:** Turkey (Asia Minor); it mentions the names of Vedic gods, dated ~1400 BC.
- Q13.** Who wrote "The Arctic Home in the Vedas"? **Ans:** Bal Gangadhar Tilak.
- Q14.** What did "Nishka" mean in the Rig Vedic period, and what did it come to mean later? **Ans:** A gold neck ornament in the early period; a coin/currency in the later period.
- Q15.** What does "Gavishthi" mean? **Ans:** "Search for cows" — used for war/battle over cattle.
- Q16.** What title was given to Indra, and what does it mean? **Ans:** Purandara — "destroyer of forts."
- Q17.** What was iron called in the Later Vedic Age? **Ans:** Shyama Ayas / Krishna Ayas.
- Q18.** Name the six Vedangas. **Ans:** Shiksha, Kalpa, Vyakaran, Nirukta, Chhanda, Jyotisha.
- Q19.** Who founded the Vaisheshika school of philosophy? **Ans:** Kannada.
- Q20.** Who founded the Nyaya school? **Ans:** Gautam.
- Q21.** What was the Vedic-era name for the river Ravi? **Ans:** Parushni.
- Q22.** What was the Vedic-era name for the river Sutlej? **Ans:** Shutudri.
- Q23.** Was the varna system hereditary in the Early Vedic Age? **Ans:** No — it was flexible/karma-based; it became rigid and hereditary only in the Later Vedic Age.
- Q24.** What was the capital of the Kuru tribe? **Ans:** Hastinapur.

- Q25.** When was the Mahabharata compiled in its present form? **Ans:** Around the 4th century AD (the war itself traditionally dated to ~950 BC).
- Q26.** Name the four Ashramas. **Ans:** Brahmacharya, Grihastha, Vanaprastha, Sanyasa.
- Q27.** Which type of inter-varna marriage was permitted, and which was not? **Ans:** Anuloma (permitted); Pratiloma (not permitted).
- Q28.** What is Gandharva vivaha? **Ans:** Love marriage.
- Q29.** What were the Vedic terms for rice, wheat and barley? **Ans:** Vrihi, Godhuma, Yava respectively.
- Q30.** What pottery is associated with the Early Vedic Age, and what with the Later Vedic Age? **Ans:** Ochre Coloured Pottery (OCP); Painted Grey Ware (PGW).
- Q31.** According to the Atharva Veda, Sabha and Samiti are described as what? **Ans:** The two daughters of Prajapati.
- Q32.** Besides agriculture, what was a significant Vedic-era occupation? **Ans:** Weaving (wool and cotton).
- Q33.** What was the predominant form of government in the Early Vedic period? **Ans:** Monarchy (hereditary kingship, with some tribal/assembly-based elements).

15. Last-Minute One-Page Revision

THE ENTIRE PART IN ONE FLOW

ARYAN MIGRATION (Boghaz-Koi, Tilak's Arctic Home) → EARLY VEDIC (1500–1000 BC: Rig Veda composed, pastoral economy, flexible varna, Sabha/Samiti active, Nishka = ornament) → VEDANGAS + DARSHANAS (tools + philosophy to understand the Vedas) → LATER VEDIC (1000–600 BC: iron discovered/Shyama Ayas, agriculture-based, rigid hereditary varna, women's status declines, Janapadas emerge, Nishka = coin, PGW pottery) → feeds directly into Mahajanapadas & Magadha (Part 4).